Offensive Words

H 1922

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A. Background

This instruction sheet provides guidance on the treatment of words considered offensive, derogatory, etc., in subject authority records. It applies to both the creation of new subject authority records and the review of existing subject authority records.

B. Recent revisions

Newly created September 2024.

C. Definition

Slurs, pejoratives, etc.: derogatory terms that insult, disparage, offend, or denigrate people according to their race, ethnicity, nationality, religion, gender identity, sexuality, occupation, social views, political views, etc. When determining whether a word represents a slur, pejorative, etc., consider the current usage of the word as defined in standard dictionaries for the language as well as relevant specialized reference sources.

Note that current usage of a word may differ from historical usage – what was once considered a slur, pejorative, etc., may no longer be (and vice versa). When in doubt, do not consider a word to be a slur, pejorative, etc., if evidence suggests that it is no longer considered offensive in current usage.

Note, too, that general usage for a word may differ from internal usage among members of the group. When in doubt, give preference to evidence that the group considers the word to be a slur, pejorative, etc., when used by persons outside the group.

D. Form of heading: Slurs, pejoratives, etc.

Etymological headings

1. When cataloging an etymological study of a word considered a slur, pejorative, etc., do not establish a Library of Congress subject heading for the word. Rather, assign a heading for the language, subdivided by ***–Slurs***, together with any other appropriate headings.

   Example:

   Title: *Slut, a journey to get a word banned*

   ```
   650 #0 $a English language $x Slurs.
   ```

2. If a heading for the language subdivided by ***–Slurs*** does not yet exist, make a proposal to establish the heading editorially. In the subject proposal, do not provide a UF reference from the word considered a slur, pejorative, etc.

3. A word considered a slur, etc., in one language will not necessarily be considered a slur, pejorative, etc., in another language. Words in the latter category may be established as Library of Congress subject headings.

   Example:

   Title: *Ecce homo! : a lexicon of man*

   ```
   650 #0 $a Homo (The Latin word)
   ```

Names of Indigenous peoples and other ethnic groups

4. A word considered a slur, pejorative, etc., should not be used in Library of Congress subject headings for Indigenous peoples and other ethnic groups, or in headings derived from such names. Prefer to establish the headings using an alternative name, ideally the one preferred by the group itself if known. Make a see reference from the form of name containing the slur, pejorative, etc.[1]

   Example:

   ```
   150 ## $a Purépecha Indians
   450 ## $w nne $a Tarasco Indians
   ```

   ```
   150 ## $a Catechisms, Purépecha
   450 ## $w nne $a Catechisms, Tarascan
   ```

Other proper names

5. A word considered a slur, pejorative, etc., may be used in Library of Congress subject headings if the word is part of a proper name (e.g., the name of a geographic place) and no alternative is known to exist. Prefer to establish the heading using an alternative name if one exists. Make a see reference from the form of name containing the slur, pejorative, etc.

   Example:

   ```
   151 ## $a Iron Mountain (Pinal County, Ariz.)
   451 ## $a Squaw Peak (Pinal County, Ariz.)
   ```

   Exception: Catalogers are required to consult certain reference sources when establishing geographic place names (cf. H 690). If an approved form of name, as found in a preferred reference source, contains a slur, pejorative, etc., base the heading on that approved form.

Homographs

6. If a word considered a slur, pejorative, etc., has additional meanings, the word may be used in Library of Congress subject headings and references when the different meaning of the word is intended. A qualifier may be used to clarify the meaning of the word.

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[1] Policies for subject authority records for Indigenous peoples and other ethnic groups are currently being reviewed. It is possible this practice regarding the use of see references may be changed in the future.

Example:

```
150 ## $a Bitches (Dogs)
450 ## $a Female dogs
```

Note fields

7. Words considered slurs, pejoratives, etc., may be recorded in Library of Congress subject authority records in note fields not intended for public display in library discovery systems (e.g., in field 670 to cite the title of the resource being cataloged or the results of research performed).

E. Form of heading: Obscenities, etc.

Etymological headings

1. Words considered obscenities, expletives, swear words, profanities, vulgarisms, etc., that are not slurs, pejoratives, etc., may be established as Library of Congress subject headings when cataloging an etymological study of the word.

Example:

```
150 ## $a Damn (The English word)
670 ## $a Work cat.: Remarks on the profane and absurd use of the
monosyllable damn, 1746.
```

Proper names

2. A word considered an obscenity, etc., may be used in Library of Congress subject headings and references if the word is part of a proper name (e.g., the name of a geographic place). Prefer to establish the heading using an alternative name if one exists. Make a see reference from the form of name containing the obscenity, etc.

Example:

```
151 ## $a Kofa Mountains (Ariz.)
451 ## $a Shit House Mountains (Ariz.)
```

Exception: Catalogers are required to consult certain reference sources when establishing geographic place names (cf. H 690). If an approved form of name, as found in a preferred reference source, contains an obscenity, etc., base the heading on that approved form.

Homographs

3. If a word considered an obscenity, etc., has additional meanings, the word may be used in Library of Congress subject headings and references when the different meaning of the word is intended. A qualifier may be used to clarify the meaning of the word.

Example:

```
150 ## $a Titmice
450 ## $a Tits (Birds)
```

Note fields

4. Words considered obscenities, etc., may be recorded in Library of Congress subject authority records in note fields not intended for public display in library discovery systems (e.g., in field 670 to cite the title of the resource being cataloged or the results of research performed).

F. Revision and cancellation of existing subject headings

Revision of existing subject headings

1. When submitting a proposal to change a subject heading containing an offensive word, make the former heading a UF reference if permitted according to the guidelines elsewhere in this instruction sheet. Staff in the Library of Congress Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division will add a history note in field 688 documenting the change from the old heading to the new heading (cf. H 225).

Example:

```
151 ## $a Red Rock Creek (Iowa)
451 ## $w nne $a Squaw Creek (Jasper County, Iowa)
688 ## $a Heading changed from Squaw Creek (Jasper County, Iowa) to Red Rock Creek (Iowa) in December 2022.
```

Cancellation of existing subject headings

2. When submitting a proposal to cancel an existing subject heading containing an offensive word, add an appropriate deleted heading note in field 682 (cf. H 193.5).

Example:

```
150 ## $a Shyster (The English word)
682 ## $i This authority record has been deleted because the heading is
covered by the subject heading $a English language--Slurs $0
(DLC)sh2023000167
```

In the record for the replacement subject heading, add an appropriate note in field 667.

Example:

```
150 ## $a English language $x Slurs
667 ## $a Record covers the following cancelled headings for individual
slurs, for which references will not be made: …
```

G. Revision history

2024-09: Newly created instruction sheet.